

Mycenaean and Greek geometric styles

The first high culture of the European mainland, the Mycenaeans arose c.2000 BCE. Greek-speaking, they were sophisticated and influenced by Minoan culture. This powerful, prosperous society produced a vast range of art and artefacts, such as pottery decorated with images of their warriors, gold funerary masks and other priceless objects that were buried with their dead rulers. They built bridges, fortifications, conical tombs and elaborate drainage and irrigation systems. Compared to the Minoans, their art is stiffer and more formal.

From c.900–700 BCE, the earliest Greek settlers produced art that was later termed the Geometric period. The population increased and art displayed geometric patterns and shapes, even in their alphabet. As worship became formalized, temples were built to house the statues of gods. The characteristics of this period are preserved in geometric monumental vases. The decorative theme of the meander, or key pattern, was a characteristic element of the time.



Late Geometric Attic Amphora, c.720-700 BCE